Lesson Observation Policy

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1. Introduction

Trent Education Centre (TEC) believes that teaching and learning is a collaborative practice where academic management, lecturers, personal tutors, other support staff and students work together in reciprocal relationships. A key part of this collaboration is the TEC approach to the development of effective teaching and learning through observation and feedback set out in this policy.

TEC believes that effective teaching and learning is generated by social interaction between students, their peers and lecturers, the application of knowledge and skills to real-world activities and critical self-reflection upon teaching and learning. Students are expected to gain in-depth subject knowledge alongside the development of communication, problem-solving and critical thinking skills that will improve their academic and career prospects, confidence and ability to learn and improve themselves independently.

2. Purpose and Scope

This policy ensures that the TEC holistic approach to learning and teaching is implemented by lecturers in the classroom by monitoring and providing feedback on the quality of teaching and learning. It ensures that staff understand the observation process and what is expected of those who observe and those who are observed.

3. Aims and Objectives

The aim of observation is to improve the standard of teaching practice if needed and to provide lecturers with ongoing professional support and development for the enhancement of teaching and learning. This is achieved through the following objectives:

- Conducting different types of observations at appropriate times throughout the academic year including formal and informal observations conducted by relevant senior staff and peers.
- Ensuring that teaching and learning are monitored effectively so that if improvements are needed, they are identified early and addressed promptly.
- Ensuring that teaching and learning are continuously enhanced.
- Ensuring that CPD workshops on teaching and learning are informed by evidence from observations.
- Providing a standardised template for use in lesson planning for observations and giving feedback to lecturers after observations.
- Providing lecturers with clear, standardised criteria for assessing formal observations so they know what the observer will be looking for.
- Providing lecturers with clear and justified recommendations and a development plan on areas where they can improve or enhance their teaching practice.

4. Formal and Informal Observations

TEC conducts four types of lesson observation for all of its lecturers in Higher Education courses as follows:

- Micro-Observations
- Formal Observations
- Peer Observations
- Learning Walks

4.1. Micro-observations

All new lecturers are given a micro-observation by the Executive Principal, Head of Quality or Programme Leader before they are hired to teach. This consists of a 20-minute observation followed by a discussion with students to get their feedback. There is no documentation or formal written feedback for these types of observations as they form part of the interview and selection process for new lecturers.

4.2. Lesson Observations (Formal)

Once appointed, new lecturers are observed within the first three weeks of teaching. If there are no significant concerns identified, lecturers are formally observed once per annum thereafter. If concerns are identified and the lecturer needs improvement, the lecturer is observed a second time no later than two weeks after the first observation. If lecturers cannot meet expected teaching standards after multiple observations, their contracts may be terminated. Formal lesson observations for higher education courses are conducted by one of the following:

- Executive Principal
- Head of Quality
- Programme Leader

The Programme Leader will be observed when teaching by the Executive Principal or the Head of Quality.

The formal lesson observation begins with a meeting between the observer and the lecturer (observee) at least one week before the observation. In this meeting, the TEC Lesson Observation Policy is discussed and the timing of the lesson observation agreed. The lecturer will have an opportunity to inform the observer about anything that should be taken into consideration. Before the lesson observation, the lecturer sends a lesson plan to the observer covering a 45-minute lesson using the TEC Lesson Plan Template (See Appendix 1). During the formal observation, the observer completes a lesson observation feedback form commenting on some or all or the following:

- **Lesson Planning**: How effectively does the lesson plan and its implementation, including the staging of activities and utilisation of resources ensure that relevant lesson objectives are met and students are able to achieve the learning outcomes.

- **Learning Management:** How effectively does the lecturer manage lesson pace, transitions between activities, student engagement and behaviour, the learning space, equipment and resources.

- **Differentiation:** How effectively does the lecturer use stretch and scaffolding to ensure that all students are appropriately challenged and supported.

- **Independent Students**: How effectively does the lecturer ensure that all students develop strategies and habits that enable them to learn with increasing confidence and autonomy.

- **Student Centred**: How effectively does the lecturer balance and manage talking time (TT) and ensure that students are fully engaged, interacting with the lecturer and each other and have agency over their learning.

- **Skills and Knowledge Development:** How effectively do students demonstrate the development of subject-specific and transferable knowledge and skills, including engagement with relevant scholarship, professional practice, critical thinking, academic literacy communication skills and evidence of prior learning and learning during the lesson.

- **Assessment of Learning:** How effectively does the lecturer use formative assessment, questioning, academic discussion, peer and self-assessment, feedback, and other appropriate strategies to monitor learning, assess understanding, and inform teaching during the lesson.

After the observation the observer will provide written feedback with general comments and their assessment on each of the items above. The observer will also select one of the following overall assessment outcomes:

- **Outstanding**
- **Very good**
- **Good**
- **Another observation required**

Another observation required indicates that key elements of effective teaching were not sufficiently evidenced during the lesson, and a follow-up observation is needed to confirm that appropriate improvements have been made.

The observer provides a development plan with recommendations on where the lecturer could enhance teaching or make improvements. If improvements are needed, the observer will monitor them during the next follow-up lesson observation two weeks later. Recommendations in the development plans for lecturers are used to inform future CPD workshops offered to lecturers.

4.3. Peer Observations

At least once per annum, all lecturers at TEC complete a 30-minute peer observation of another lecturer and are peer-observed by another lecturer. During peer observations, lecturers complete a Peer Observation Form in which they identify areas of good practice and offer suggestions on how the lesson they observed might be enhanced for future practice.

4.4. Learning Walks

At least once per annum the Executive Principal, Head of Quality or Programme Leader may conduct a learning walk. This involves entering a lesson unannounced and observing for about 15-30 minutes. During the learning walk, the observer will not complete any documentation but will observe and provide some verbal feedback to the lecturer when the lesson ends. If the observer has any concerns, they may arrange a formal lesson observation with the lecturer after the learning walk has ended.

5. Appendices

Staff are required to use the templates in the appendices when planning lessons, providing feedback on lessons and giving feedback on the observation process. These templates include the following:

- Lesson Plan
- Lesson Observation Feedback Form with Development Plan
- Peer Observation Form
- Lecturer Feedback Form

Lesson Plan

Course Title				**Start Date**		**End Date**	
Topic		**Lecturer**		**Week Number**		**Lesson Date**	
Group Profile				**Lesson Objectives** The lecturer will: **Learning Outcomes** The students will be able to:			
Stage	**Interaction**	**Mins**	**Activity Procedure**	**Aim**		**Differentiation**	**Resources**

Appendix 1: Lesson Observation Feedback Form

Lecturer		**Date**	
Observer		**Time**	
Title of Course		**Location**	
Module or Unit		**Lesson Title**	
Cohort		**Number Enrolled**	
In-person or online		**Number Attending**	

General Comments

Feedback

Criterion	Standard	Met (Y/N)	Good Practice	Areas for Improvement
Lesson Planning	The lesson plan supports the teaching objectives and learning outcomes and effectively implemented, with clear staging, realistic timings, and appropriate detail. Materials are appropriate, well-selected, and exploited effectively to meet learning outcomes.			
Learning Management	Pace, transitions, engagement, behaviour, and use of learning space, equipment and resources.			
Differentiation	All students are appropriately challenged and supported with stretch and scaffolding according to their needs, levels, and interests.			
Independent Students	Students are supported to develop strategies and habits that help them develop confidence and autonomy.			

Student Centred	Talking time (TT) is well-balanced and managed; students are actively engaged, interacting with the lecturers and each other, and exercising agency over their learning.			
Skills and Knowledge Development	Students demonstrate their development of subject-specific and transferable knowledge and skills, including engagement with relevant scholarship, professional practice, critical thinking, academic literacy, communication skills and evidence of prior learning and learning during the lesson.			
Assessment of Learning	Understanding is monitored and assessed at differentiated levels through formative assessment, questioning, academic discussion, peer and self-assessment, feedback, and other appropriate strategies.			

Observation Outcome	**YES/NO**
Outstanding	
Very Good	
Good	
Another observation required	

Development Plan

Action Points		Deadline	Updates
	Name	**Date**	
Observer			
Lecturer			

Appendix 2: Peer Observation Form

Peer Observer's Feedback	
Please observe one of your peers and write some comments below.	
Name of Lecturer	
Name of Observer	
Date	
Time (30 minutes)	
Examples of good teaching practice observed, why they were effective and the impact they may have on your own teaching	
Based on the lesson observed, give some constructive suggestions that may support the lecturer's continued development	

Appendix 3: Lecturer Feedback Form

Lecturer's Feedback to the Observer			
Please complete this form and email it to the observer.			
Lecturer's Name			
Date of Observation			
Observer's Name			
Observer's email			
Do you feel that the observer's feedback is accurate?			
YES/NO **Please say why**			
Do you think that the feedback provided will influence how you teach in future?			
YES/NO **Please explain why**			
Role	**Name**	**Signature**	**Date**
Lecturer			
Observer			